

MAXX STEELE™

PROGRAMMER'S TECHNICAL REFERENCE GUIDE



RoboForce

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Maxx Steele Technical Manual

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1 Maxx Steele Technical Manual

This manual describes how to program the 1984 CBS Toys / Ideal **Maxx Steele** robot at the software level: bytecode motion programs, speech, music, cartridge images, and the 6502 internal ROM that interprets them.

It is modeled on the structure of the Commodore 64 Programmer's Reference Guide — numbered chapters, appendices, a quick-reference card, and a schematic index — adapted to Maxx Steele hardware.

PDF (latest): [Maxx-Steele-Technical-Manual.pdf](#) — front/rear covers plus chapters; rebuilt when .md or cover images change (python3 tools/build_technical_manual_pdf.py locally; GitHub Actions on push to main).

1.1 What this guide covers

Document	Audience	Focus
This guide	Programmers, reverse engineers	Bytecode language, memory map, I/O, internal ROM hooks
Cartridge/PROGRAMMING.md	Cartridge authors	Step-by-step cart layout, tools, demo walkthrough
Chassis/Manual/	Owners	Factory user / reference manuals (operation, not ROM layout)

Primary sources: R. Wind disassemblies ([maxx_internal_ROM.dsm](#) (Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_internal_ROM.dsm), [maxx_demo_ROM_532.dsm](#) (Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_demo_ROM_532.dsm), [tools/maxx_rom.py](#)).

1.2 How to use this reference guide

If you are new to Maxx programming, read in order:

1. Chapter 1 — Bytecode programming rules
2. Chapter 2 — Opcode vocabulary
3. Chapter 3 — Motion and display
4. Work through the demo program in Cartridge/PROGRAMMING.md §5

If you are writing cartridges, add:

5. Chapter 5 — Cartridge bootstrap and internal ROM
6. Chapter 7 — UltraMaxx BASIC language
7. Cartridge/PROGRAMMING.md §9 (authoring workflow)

If you are reverse engineering hardware, use:

- Chapter 6 — Input/output guide
- Schematics
- Annotated .dsm listings under Chassis/Firmware/ and Cartridge/Examples/

Keep Quick reference and Appendices open while coding.

1.3 Applications guide

Application	Mode (\$00)	What you need
Remote control (immediate)	0	Remote keypad; opcodes executed live
Learn key sequences	1	Records into program RAM
Enter program steps	2	Keypad maps to opcodes via \$E6B5 table
Run stored program	3	Bytecode at \$0200, terminator FF FF
Factory demo	3 + cart	CBSDemo.532 (Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/bootstrap)
Custom cartridge	3 + cart	4 KB EPROM image; see Ch 5-7 + cartridge manual
UltraMaxx BASIC authoring	3 + cart	Ch 7; maxx compile → .532
Speech / music authoring	any	Ch 4; phrase tables in cart or RAM
Repair / RE	—	Ch 6, Schematics, DataSheets/

1.4 Table of contents

Chapter	Title
—	Introduction (this file)
1	Bytecode programming rules
2	Opcode vocabulary
3	Programming motion and display
4	Programming speech and music
5	Cartridge bootstrap and internal ROM
6	Input/output guide
7	UltraMaxx BASIC language

Chapter	Title
A-L	Appendices
—	Quick reference card
—	Schematic diagram index

1.5 Firmware images in this archive

Image	Path
Internal 8 KB ROM	Chassis/Firmware/Binary/Maxxrom.64
Demo cartridge (4 KB)	Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Binary
UltraMaxx cartridge (4 KB)	Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Binary

Tools: `tools/maxx` — compile UltraMaxx BASIC, validate, list, upload; `tools/maxx_rom.py` — disassemble, template, opcode export.

2 Chapter 1 — Bytecode Programming Rules

This chapter describes the rules for writing Maxx Steele **programs**: how bytecode is stored, how operating modes affect entry, and practical techniques for building sequences.

The robot does not run arbitrary user 6502 code for motion demos. The internal ROM interprets a **bytecode program** in RAM. Cartridges supply tables and a short bootstrap stub; see Chapter 5.

2.1 Introduction

A Maxx program is a linear sequence of (**opcode, operand**) byte pairs. Each pair is one step. The executor reads from program RAM, displays the opcode name on the LED segment display, and performs the action.

Programs are edited through the remote keypad (Program mode), loaded from a cartridge bootstrap, or built offline and burned into EPROM.

2.2 Program storage

Property	Value
RAM region	\$0200-03FE
Step size	2 bytes (opcode, operand)
Maximum steps	255 pairs (512 bytes); FULL displayed when \$037F exceeded
Terminator	FF FF (required)

Example minimal program:

```
83 10    ; speak RAM phrase 0
0C 03    ; delay 3 seconds
01 10    ; drive forward
0B 00    ; home all joints
FF FF    ; end
```

2.3 Operating modes (\$00)

The mode byte in zero page selects how keypad input and the executor behave.

Value	Name	Behavior
\$00	Immediate	Keys execute motion/speech instantly
\$01	Learn	Records key sequences into program RAM
\$02	Program	Enter bytecode steps via keypad
\$03	Execute / Game	Run the stored program

Cartridge entry stubs typically initialize status bytes \$02 and \$03 before jumping to the internal main loop at \$E0B6.

2.4 Status bytes

2.4.1 \$02 — Status A

Set by cartridge bootstrap (demo uses LDA #\$02 / STA \$02). Bits include speech error (**SEr**), enable backoff (**Ebof**), power-down, drive, and speech flags. Keypad rows toggle subsets; see Appendix E.

2.4.2 \$03 — Status B

Demo entry uses LDA #\$82 / STA \$03 (**PDon**, **Edof**, **SPof**, **UCon**). Governs user control and execute gating.

2.5 Program pointers (zero page)

Addr	Role
\$0F / \$10	Current step in \$0200 table (program mode / execute)
\$11 / \$13	Current opcode and operand during entry
\$24 / \$25	Program byte pointer used by executor

2.6 Programming techniques

2.6.1 Delays

Opcode \$0C operand is delay time in **seconds** (decimal). Chain delays between motion commands so mechanics can finish.

0C 02 ; wait 2 seconds

01 14 ; forward (operand scale empirical – see Ch 3)

0C 04 ; wait 4 seconds

2.6.2 Homing

Opcode \$0B with operand **\$00 only** — returns joints to a known position before the next move.

2.6.3 Speech then motion

RAM phrases (\$83) must be copied to \$0500 before execute (cartridge stub or prior setup). ROM phrases (\$82) need no RAM table.

2.6.4 Program length

If program entry exceeds available RAM, the display shows **FULL** (internal ROM compares against \$037F).

2.6.5 Marker opcode \$FE

Display-only **beg** marker; does not affect execution flow in the demo cart.

2.7 Beginner checklist

1. Every program ends with FF FF.
2. Operands are one byte (\$00-FF); meaning depends on opcode (Ch 2-4).
3. Test with python3 tools/maxx_rom.py validate before burning EPROM.
4. For a worked 38-step demo, see Cartridge/PROGRAMMING.md §5.

Next: Chapter 2 — Opcode vocabulary

3 Chapter 2 — Opcode Vocabulary

This chapter lists every known Maxx Steele program opcode. Display names come from the internal ROM segment table at **\$F878** (see Appendix B).

Opcodes are described in **hex order** within each group. For a one-page summary, see Quick reference.

Export machine-readable opcode JSON:

```
python3 tools/maxx_rom.py opcodes Cartridge/opcodes.json
```

3.1 Motion and I/O opcodes (\$00-\$10)

Opcode	Display	Name	Operand
\$00	L	Turn / drive left	Distance or angle
\$01	F	Drive forward	Distance
\$02	b	Drive reverse	Distance
\$03	r	Turn / drive right	Angle
\$04	Uu	Wrist up	Value
\$05	Ud	Wrist down	Value
\$06	Au	Arms up	Value
\$07	Ad	Arms down	Value
\$08	Cr	Claw rotate	Value
\$09	Cc	Claw open/close	\$00=open, \$01=close
\$0A	HL	Lamp	\$00=off, \$01=on
\$0B	init	Home (all joints)	Must be \$00
\$0C	d	Delay	Seconds
\$0D	Sn	Song number reference	Index
\$0E	S	Speech (ROM phrase)	Phrase #
\$0F	SS	Speech (shift mode)	Phrase #
\$10	PS	Program speech capture	Slot #

Examples

```
01 14    ; forward
0A 01    ; lamp on
0C 0A    ; delay 10 seconds
82 3F    ; speak ROM phrase $3F
```

3.2 Extended opcodes (\$80-\$FF)

Opcodes with bit 7 set (\$80+) are remapped through the display table for execution. The executor treats \$80 as an alias mapping to display index \$0C.

Opcode	Display	Name	Operand
\$81	PLAY	Play tune from music RAM	Tune # (\$0400 table)
\$82	SPEE	Speak ROM phrase	Phrase #
\$83	SS	Speak RAM phrase	Phrase # in \$0500
\$84	CLr	Clear speech phrase slot	Slot #
\$FE	beg	Program begin marker	Display only
\$FF	End	End of program	Must be \$FF (pair FF FF)

3.3 Keypad-mapped opcodes

The internal ROM maps remote key scan codes to opcodes via table **\$E6B5**. Faceplate names: Transmitter/remote-keypad.md. Documented mapping (from maxx_internal_ROM.dsm (Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_internal_ROM.dsm)):

Key opcodes: 00 01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 0A 0B 0C 0D 0E 0F
41 46 43 13 84 82 81 83 80

Opcode	Typical keypad use
\$41	Game-related step
\$43	Click
\$46	Motion step
\$13	(mapped key — see learn/program mode)
\$80-\$84	Extended speech/music/clear group

In **Program mode**, pressing a key stores the mapped opcode and prompts for an operand byte.

3.4 Alphabetical index

Name	Opcode
arms_down	\$07
arms_up	\$06
claw_open_close	\$09
claw_rotate	\$08
delay	\$0C
drive_forward	\$01
drive_reverse	\$02
end	\$FF
home	\$0B
lamp	\$0A
play_tune	\$81
song_number	\$0D
speak_ram	\$83
speak_rom	\$82
speech_clear	\$84
speech_program	\$10
speech_rom	\$0E
speech_shift	\$0F
turn_left	\$00
turn_right	\$03
wrist_down	\$05
wrist_up	\$04

3.5 Unknown opcodes

If the executor encounters an undefined opcode, behavior is undefined in this documentation. Stick to opcodes listed above and validated with tools/maxx_rom.py.

Previous: Chapter 1 · **Next:** Chapter 3 — Motion and display

4 Chapter 3 — Programming Motion and Display

This chapter describes motion opcodes, the headlamp, and how the LED display shows program steps during entry and execution.

Distance and angle **operands are empirical** — the internal ROM scales them to motor timing. Values in the factory demo (e.g. \$14 forward, \$28 arm raise) are starting points, not documented engineering units.

4.1 Motion overview

Drive and joint motion opcodes \$00-\$09 write timing values to motor control hardware mapped around **\$1600** and **\$1C00** (see Chapter 6).

The executor runs each step to completion (or until interrupted) before advancing the program pointer at \$0200.

4.2 Drive opcodes

Opcode	Action	Demo cart examples
\$00	Turn left	00 05
\$01	Forward	01 14, 01 10
\$02	Reverse	02 14
\$03	Turn right	03 06

Operands control how long or how far the drive system runs. Compare steps in maxx_demo_ROM_532.dsm (Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_demo_ROM_532.dsm) with on-robot behavior when calibrating new values.

4.3 Arm and wrist opcodes

Opcode	Action	Demo example
\$04	Wrist up	—
\$05	Wrist down	05 23
\$06	Arms up	06 28
\$07	Arms down	—
\$08	Claw rotate	08 15
\$09	Claw open/close	09 00 (open)

4.4 Home opcode \$0B

Always use operand **00**:

0B 00 ; home – all joints to reference position

The demo cart homes before backing up at the end of the sequence.

4.5 Lamp opcode \$0A

Operand	Effect
\$00	Lamp off
\$01	Lamp on

Demo sequence: 0A 01 ... delay ... 0A 00.

4.6 LED segment display

During program entry and execution, the internal ROM fetches a **two-byte display code** from table **\$F878** indexed by the current opcode (see LDA \$F878,Y in maxx_internal_ROM.dsm (Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_internal_ROM.dsm)). This drives the shift-register display at **\$1200**.

Display names in Chapter 2 match that table (e.g. **L**, **F**, **PLAY**, **d**).

When program RAM is full, the display spells **FULL** (bytes at internal ROM label referencing \$037F limit).

4.7 Programming techniques

1. **Home after motion blocks** — reduces accumulated joint error.
2. **Delay after every drive** — allows the chassis to settle before the next command.
3. **Lamp as status** — signal “busy” during long speech delays.
4. **Small operand sweeps** — test \$01 08, \$01 10, \$01 14 on your robot and record what works.

4.8 Known gaps

- Exact mm/degree mapping for operands is not documented in the internal ROM listing.
- Motor ramp profiles and limit switches are hardware-dependent; see Mainboard/Schematic/ and future KiCad RE.

Previous: Chapter 2 · **Next:** Chapter 4 — Speech and music

5 Chapter 4 — Programming Speech and Music

This chapter describes how the Maxx Steele robot produces speech and music under program control.

Speech uses a parallel phoneme interface at **\$1400**. The speech driver subroutine **\$F3D5** clocks 4-bit nybbles to the synthesizer. Music uses byte pairs in RAM at **\$0400** and an IRQ handler near **\$F1D8**.

5.1 Speech overview

Mechanism	Opcode	Data source
ROM phrase table	\$82, \$0E	Internal ROM phoneme strings
RAM phrase table	\$83	\$0500 (copied from cartridge or recorded)
Program speech capture	\$10	User-recorded slots
Clear phrase slot	\$84	Clears RAM slot

5.2 ROM phrases (\$82 / \$0E)

Phrases are indexed phoneme strings in internal ROM. The driver at **\$F3D5** outputs sounds with index **X** (see JSR **\$F3D5** in `maxx_internal_ROM.dsm` (Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/`maxx_internal_ROM.dsm`)). Phoneme code tables reside at **\$F567 / \$F4DB** (140 entries). Until the full **\$F4DB** table is transcribed, treat phrase indices as opaque IDs.

Demo examples:

```
82 3F      ; "Ha ha ha ha ha" (ROM)
83 16      ; uses ROM index via RAM phrase indirection in demo – see cart listing
```

5.3 RAM phrases (\$83)

Cartridges embed phrase data at offset **\$81** (address **\$A081** for demo cart). The bootstrap copies bytes to **\$0500**.

Each phrase is a sequence of **16-bit phoneme tokens**; **\$FF** pads unused slots.

Demo cart phrase table (from `maxx_demo_ROM_532.dsm` (Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Assembly/`maxx_demo_ROM_532.dsm`)):

Slot	Content (abbrev.)
0	“Hello, I am Maxx Steele” / greeting tokens
1	“I am ready when you are”
2	“I am a great match for humans”
3	“Goodbye for now, have a good day”

Example program bytes:

```
83 10      ; speak RAM phrase 0 (demo uses operand $10 for table indexing –
verify in .dsm)
0C 02      ; delay
83 00      ; another RAM phrase
```

Note: Demo listing uses operands \$10, \$00, \$01, etc. — cross-check against your cart image with `maxx_rom.py disasm`.

5.4 Music overview

Opcode **\$81** plays a tune from the music RAM table at **\$0400**.

Tune selection calls **\$EF01** to resolve pointers for tune number in the operand (multiple call sites in internal ROM).

5.4.1 Music byte pairs

Stored in **\$0400** (and cartridge offset **\$BB / \$A0BB**):

```
70 12    ; note
70 11    ; note
38 0F
54 0D
E0 0F
00 00    ; end of tune
```

The music IRQ handler at **\$F1D8** reads duration data from **\$F15B** and frequency/note data from **\$0400**.

Demo: 81 06 plays tune #6 (Reveille); 81 00 plays tune #0 at end of demo sequence.

5.5 Song number opcode \$0D

References a song index for the internal song table (distinct from \$81 play-tune in some keypad contexts). Used in learn/program flows.

5.6 Advanced notes

- **Phoneme authoring** requires transcribing **\$F4DB / \$F567** — listed as future work in Cartridge/PROGRAMMING.md §10.
- **Speech error flag (SEr** in **\$02**) — set when speech subsystem reports fault; demo cart entry sets related status.
- Face/speech hardware datasheets: DataSheets/ (Sanyo LC3100/LC8100, ET9420 family).

Previous: Chapter 3 · **Next:** Chapter 5 — Cartridge and internal ROM

6 Chapter 5 — Cartridge Bootstrap and Internal ROM

This chapter explains the relationship between **6502 machine code** in cartridge ROM and the **bytecode interpreter** in the robot's 8 KB internal ROM.

6.1 What is the internal ROM?

At power-on the **MOS 6502** CPU executes firmware in **\$E000-FFFF** (8 KB). This code is the robot's only native language — analogous to the C64 KERNAL + BASIC ROM, but specialized for:

- Keypad scan and mode handling
- Bytecode fetch/decode from \$0200
- Speech, music, motor, and display drivers
- Cartridge detection and bootstrap handoff

User programs are **not** generally written in 6502. They are bytecode tables interpreted by this ROM.

Source listing: Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_internal_ROM.dsm

Binary: Chassis/Firmware/Binary/Maxxrom.64

6.2 What is a cartridge?

A **4 KB EPROM** plugs into the cartridge slot, mapped into **\$2000-B000** in 4 KB steps. The factory demo sits at **\$A000**.

A valid image supplies:

1. Entry vector and copyright header
2. A short **6502 bootstrap stub**
3. Program, speech, and music **data tables**

The stub copies tables into RAM and jumps to the internal main loop — it does **not** replace the interpreter.

6.3 Cartridge ROM layout (\$A000 base)

Offset	Size	Content
\$00	2	Entry vector (word), e.g. \$A013
\$02	17	Copyright: (c) 1985 CBS Toys
\$13	code	Bootstrap stub (6502)
\$35	table	Program bytecode
\$81	table	Speech phrases (opcode \$83)
\$BB	table	Music notes (opcode \$81)

Cartridge detection scans 4 KB boundaries from \$2000 upward, comparing the copyright string at offset +2.

6.4 Bootstrap stub (demo cart)

Entry at **\$A013** (maxx_demo_ROM_532.dsm (Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_

1. STA \$02 / STA \$03 — initialize status flags
2. Copy program from **\$A035 → \$0200**
3. Copy phrases from **\$A081 → \$0500**
4. Copy music from **\$A0BB → \$0400**
5. **JMP \$E0B6** — enter internal ROM main loop

Expected entry prologue: A9 02 85 02 (LDA #\$02 / STA \$02). tools/maxx_rom.py validate (tools/maxx_rom.py) checks this.

6.5 Key internal ROM addresses

Address	Role
\$E0B6	Main loop entry after cartridge bootstrap
\$E0D1	Alternate loop / mode handler (JMP \$E0D1 sites)
\$E6B5	Keycode → opcode translation table
\$F878	Opcode → LED segment display table
\$F3D5	Speech output subroutine
\$F1D8	Music IRQ handler region
\$EF01	Tune pointer resolver (music)
\$F15B	Note duration table

6.6 6502 vs bytecode — when to use which

Task	Language
Motion/speech demo sequence	Bytecode in \$0200
Custom phrases/music in cart	Data tables + bootstrap
Patch OS behavior	6502 patch (advanced RE only)
New cartridge program	Bootstrap stub (minimal 6502) + bytecode tables

Do not place arbitrary 6502 execution paths in the demo program area unless you fully understand cartridge mapping and internal ROM expectations.

6.7 Tools and authoring

Step-by-step cartridge creation: Cartridge/PROGRAMMING.md §9.

```
python3 tools/maxx_rom.py template mycart.532
python3 tools/maxx_rom.py validate mycart.532
python3 tools/maxx_rom.py disasm mycart.532 --compare-dsm Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/F
```

EPROM type: Mitsubishi KM2365 family — DataSheets/Mitsubishi-KM2365.pdf.

6.8 Known gaps

- Full subroutine catalog for \$E000-FFFF not yet indexed (see Appendix I).
- Padding at \$A0C7+ in demo image marked “not Maxx-related” in .dsm — treat as unused.

Previous: Chapter 4 · **Next:** Chapter 6 — I/O guide

7 Chapter 6 — Input/Output Guide

This chapter describes memory-mapped hardware, the remote keypad, cartridge slot, and the 27 MHz radio control link.

7.1 Memory map summary

Region	Address	Purpose
Zero page	\$0000–\$00FF	Flags, pointers, keypad state
Warm start	\$0100–\$0103	Copyright mirror
Stack	\$01FF ↓	6502 stack
Program RAM	\$0200–\$03FE	Bytecode (2 bytes/step)
Music RAM	\$0400–\$04FF	Note pairs
Speech RAM	\$0500+	Custom phrases
Timer / misc	\$1000	I/O
Display	\$1200	Shift-register LEDs
Speech chip	\$1400	Parallel phoneme output
Motors	\$1600, \$1C00	Drive and joint timing
Cartridge ROM	\$2000–\$B000	4 KB slot stepping
Internal ROM	\$E000–\$FFFF	8 KB operating system

Full table: Appendix C.

7.2 Remote keypad (RF input)

The handheld transmitter uses a **COP411L** MCU scanning a row/column matrix. Key events are encoded as **27 MHz OOK** packets received by the robot superhet strip.

7.2.1 Matrix layout

	L7	L6	L5	L4	PK
D0	A	B	C	D	
D1	E	F	G	H	
L0	I	J	K	L	
L1	M	N	O	P	
L2	Q	R	S	T	
L3	U	V	W	X	
Gnd					Y

Faceplate labels (from Remote-Front.jpg (Transmitter/Photos/Product/Remote-Front.jpg)): **U/1/2/3 DRIVE, 4/5 WRIST, 6/7 ARMS, 8/9 CLAW, A LAMP, B HOME, NOTE REST (WAIT), SHIFT OCTAVE, CLEAR, ENTER, SONG/NOTES, CLOCK/STATUS, SPEECH, MOTION, GAME, PROGRAM, LEARN, EXECUTE, POWER/STOP (Y).**

Full key-to-matrix table: Transmitter/remote-keypad.md. Diagram: Remote-Front.svg (Transmitter/Photos/Product/Remote-Front.svg).

Matrix wiring refs: keyboard-matrix-reference-1.png (Transmitter/Photos/ReverseEngineering/matrix-reference-1.png), keyboard-matrix-reference-2.png (Transmitter/Photos/ReverseEngineering/matrix-reference-2.png).

7.2.2 RF link (summary)

- Carrier: **27 MHz** on-off keying
- MCU clock: **455 kHz** ceramic resonator (IF reference)
- Bit period: **~1.55 ms**; packet repeat **~29 ms** (Power/Stop **~21 ms**)

Details: Transmitter/transmitter-architecture.md, tools/rfcap/.

7.3 Cartridge expansion

Property	Value
ROM size	4 KB per image
Mapping	\$2000, \$6000, \$A000, ... (4 KB steps)
Demo cart base	\$A000
Required header	17-byte CBS Toys copyright at offset +2

Hardware EPROM: see DataSheets/Mitsubishi-KM2365.pdf.

7.4 On-board speech and face hardware

Speech synthesis ICs documented in DataSheets/ include Sanyo LC3100/LC8100 and Eurotechnique ET9420 family parts. The CPU writes phoneme nybbles to **\$1400**.

Face/display COP41xL subsystem: National-COP41xL-Display-Motors.pdf (DataSheets/National-COP41xL-Display-Motors.pdf) (refdes **U500** in archive naming).

7.5 CPU and support chips

Part	Role	Datasheet
MOS 6502	Main CPU	MOS-6502.pdf (DataSheets/MOS-6502.pdf)
COP420 family	Auxiliary MCU	National-COP420.pdf (DataSheets/National-COP420.pdf)
M6116	Static RAM	Mitsubishi-M6116.pdf (DataSheets/Mitsubishi-M6116.pdf)

CPU pinout notes (project doc): Maxx-Steele-CPU-Pinout.pdf (DataSheets/Maxx-Steele-CPU-Pinout.pdf).

7.6 Schematics

See Schematic diagram index for board-level drawings.

Previous: Chapter 5 · **Next:** Chapter 7 — UltraMaxx BASIC

8 Chapter 7 — UltraMaxx BASIC Language

This chapter describes **UltraMaxx BASIC** — a line-oriented programming language for authoring Maxx Steele cartridge programs without hand-editing bytecode. UltraMaxx BASIC is a **compiler language**, not an interpreter: each statement becomes one (**opcode**, **operand**) pair in the cartridge program table (see Chapter 1).

UltraMaxx BASIC is intentionally small. It is **not** Commodore 64 BASIC: there are no variables, no IF/THEN, no GOTO, and no arithmetic expressions. Think of it as a readable front end to the opcode vocabulary in Chapter 2.

Tools: tools/maxx (command line), tools/maxxbas/ (Rust compiler).

Example sources: ultramaxx.bas (Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Basic/ultramaxx.cbsdemo.bas (Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Basic/cbsdemo.bas), hello.bas (Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Basic/hello.bas).

8.1 Introduction

The factory demo cartridge (CBSDemo.532 (Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Binary/CBSDemo.532) stores its 38-step sequence as raw bytes at ROM address **\$A035**. UltraMaxx BASIC lets you write the same sequence as text:

```
FORWARD 20
DELAY 4
ARMS UP 40
END
```

The compiler emits a standard **4096-byte** cartridge image (.532) with bootstrap stub, copyright string, program table, and optional phrase/music tables — the layout described in Chapter 5.

After compile, upload the image with PicoROM or burn EPROM. The robot runs the program through the normal internal ROM executor at **\$E000**; the cartridge does not interpret BASIC at runtime.

8.2 Getting started

Add the toolchain to your path once:

```
export PATH="$(git rev-parse --show-toplevel)/tools/bin:$PATH"
```

Compile a source file:

```
maxx compile myprogram.bas -o mycart.532 --copyright ultramaxx
maxx validate mycart.532
```

Upload to a socketed PicoROM:

```
maxx upload myprogram.bas --device maxx_cart --copyright ultramaxx
```

Parse without writing output:

```
maxx check myprogram.bas
```

List program steps (JSON for simulators):

```
maxx list mycart.532 --json
```

8.3 Program format

8.3.1 Lines

A program is a text file, one statement per line. Blank lines are ignored.

Line numbers are optional and may be used for editor convenience (as in C64 listings). The compiler strips a leading numeric prefix:

```
10 DELAY 2
20 FORWARD 20
30 END
```

8.3.2 Comments

Two comment forms are accepted:

Form	Example
REM at start of line	REM wait for motors
REM after a statement	FORWARD 20 REM short roll
# to end of line	LAMP ON # headlamp

Comments are not stored in the ROM image.

8.3.3 Statement syntax

- Keywords are **case-insensitive** (delay, DELAY, Delay are equivalent).
- Operands are unsigned integers **0-255** (decimal or 0x hex).
- Multi-word keywords use spaces: LAMP ON, ARMS UP, CLAW OPEN.

8.3.4 Program terminator

Every program must end with **END**, which compiles to **FF FF**. If you omit END, the compiler appends it automatically.

8.4 Program size limits

Limit	Value	Notes
Steps per cartridge program	38 pairs max	Program ROM area \$A035-\$A080 (76 bytes)
Operand range	0-255	One byte per step
Factory demo length	38 pairs	Fills the cartridge program slot
RAM program buffer	~255 pairs	\$0200 region; larger than cart ROM

If you exceed 38 pairs, the compiler reports **program too large**. Short programs (for example hello.bas (Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Basic/hello.bas)) are valid; unused program bytes in ROM are filled with **\$FF**.

The robot may accept longer sequences entered from the remote in Program mode, but a **standard 4 KB cart image** cannot ship more than 38 compiled steps without changing the fixed table layout.

8.5 UltraMaxx BASIC statements

Each statement maps to one bytecode pair. The **Byte** column shows the emitted (opcode, operand) in hex.

8.5.1 DELAY

Format: DELAY *seconds*

Action: Pause execution. Operand is delay time in **seconds** (opcode \$0C).

Example	Bytes
DELAY 2	0C 02
DELAY 10	0C 0A

8.5.2 Drive: FORWARD, BACK, LEFT, RIGHT

Format: FORWARD *n* · BACK *n* · LEFT *n* · RIGHT *n*

Action: Drive or turn. Operand scaling is empirical — see Chapter 3.

Statement	Opcode	Demo example
FORWARD 20	\$01	01 14
BACK 20	\$02	02 14
LEFT 5	\$00	00 05
RIGHT 6	\$03	03 06

8.5.3 ARMS UP / ARMS DOWN

Format: ARMS UP *n* · ARMS DOWN *n*

Action: Raise or lower both arms (opcodes \$06 / \$07).

Example	Bytes
ARMS UP 40	06 28
ARMS DOWN 30	07 1E

8.5.4 WRIST UP / WRIST DOWN

Format: WRIST UP *n* · WRIST DOWN *n*

Action: Wrist joint motion (opcodes \$04 / \$05).

Example	Bytes
WRIST DOWN 35	05 23

8.5.5 CLAW ROTATE / CLAW OPEN / CLAW CLOSE

Format: CLAW ROTATE *n* · CLAW OPEN · CLAW CLOSE

Action: Claw rotate (\$08), open (\$09/\$00), close (\$09/\$01).

Example	Bytes
CLAW ROTATE 21	08 15
CLAW OPEN	09 00
CLAW CLOSE	09 01

8.5.6 LAMP ON / LAMP OFF

Format: LAMP ON · LAMP OFF

Action: Head lamp (opcode \$0A).

Example	Bytes
LAMP ON	0A 01
LAMP OFF	0A 00

8.5.7 HOME

Format: HOME

Action: Return all joints to reference position. Operand is always **\$00**.

Example	Bytes
HOME	0B 00

8.5.8 PLAY

Format: PLAY *tune*

Action: Play a tune from the cartridge music table (opcode \$81). Tune data lives at ROM **\$A0BB** (copied to RAM **\$0400**). See Chapter 4.

Example	Bytes
PLAY 6	81 06
PLAY 0	81 00

8.5.9 SAY

Format: SAY *phrase*

Action: Speak a **RAM phrase** by slot number (opcode \$83). Phrase bytes must exist in the cartridge phrase table at **\$A081** (copied to RAM **\$0500**).

Example	Bytes	Factory demo text
SAY 16	83 10	"Hello, I am Maxx Steele"
SAY 0	83 00	"I am great, and you"

UltraMaxx BASIC does **not** yet compile quoted strings (SAY "HELLO") into phoneme nybbles. Use **SPEAK** for built-in ROM speech, or compile with **--tables-from** to copy phrase bytes from a reference ROM (see \$Phrase and music tables below).

8.5.10 SPEAK

Format: SPEAK *phrase*

Action: Speak a **ROM phrase** by index (opcode \$82). Uses built-in phoneme data in internal ROM — no cart phrase table required.

Example	Bytes	Notes
SPEAK 63	82 3F	Laugh (factory demo)

8.5.11 END

Format: END

Action: Terminate the program. Both bytes must be **\$FF**.

Example	Bytes
END	FF FF

8.6 Statement summary table

UltraMaxx BASIC	Opcode	Operand
DELAY <i>n</i>	\$0C	seconds
FORWARD <i>n</i>	\$01	distance
BACK <i>n</i>	\$02	distance
LEFT <i>n</i>	\$00	distance/angle
RIGHT <i>n</i>	\$03	angle
WRIST UP <i>n</i>	\$04	value
WRIST DOWN <i>n</i>	\$05	value
ARMS UP <i>n</i>	\$06	value
ARMS DOWN <i>n</i>	\$07	value
CLAW ROTATE <i>n</i>	\$08	value
CLAW OPEN	\$09	\$00
CLAW CLOSE	\$09	\$01
LAMP ON / OFF	\$0A	\$01 / \$00
HOME	\$0B	\$00
PLAY <i>n</i>	\$81	tune index
SPEAK <i>n</i>	\$82	ROM phrase
SAY <i>n</i>	\$83	RAM phrase slot
END	\$FF	\$FF

8.7 Copyright strings

The compiler writes a 17-byte copyright field at ROM offset **\$02**. Choose with **--copyright:**

Value	String	Typical use
ultramaxx	(c) UltraMaxx	Community cartridges
cbs	(c) 1985 CBS Toys	CBS factory branding

Cartridge detection in internal ROM compares this field during warm start.

8.8 Phrase and music tables

Programs that use **SAY** or **PLAY** need matching data in the cart tables at **\$A081** and **\$A0BB**. The compiler fills these regions with **\$FF / \$00** unless you supply a reference image:

```
maxx compile ultramaxx.bas -o UltraMaxx.bas.532 \
  --copyright ultramaxx \
  --tables-from Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Binary/UltraMaxx.532
```

This copies phrase and music bytes from the reference ROM while replacing the program table with your compiled source. The full factory demo in `ultramaxx.bas` (Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Basic/`ultramaxx.bas`) compiles **byte-identical** to stock `UltraMaxx.532` (Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Binary/`UltraMaxx.532`) when tables are copied from that file.

Custom speech authoring (phoneme encoding) remains future work — see Chapter 4 and Cartridge/PROGRAMMING.md §10.

8.9 Sample programs

8.9.1 Minimal program

```
DELAY 1
FORWARD 20
LAMP ON
DELAY 3
LAMP OFF
HOME
END
```

Source: `hello.bas` (Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Basic/`hello.bas`).

8.9.2 Factory demo (38 steps)

The complete CBS/UltraMaxx demonstration sequence — speech, motion, lamp, tunes, home, and backup — is available as:

Branding	Source
CBS Toys	<code>cbsdemo.bas</code> (Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Basic/ <code>cbsdemo.bas</code>)
UltraMaxx	<code>ultramaxx.bas</code> (Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/Firmware/Basic/ <code>ultramaxx.bas</code>)

Both sources compile to the same motion program; only the copyright string differs.

8.10 Compiler errors

UltraMaxx BASIC reports line-numbered errors at compile time (not on the robot display).

Message	Cause
empty program	No statements in file
unknown statement	Keyword not in vocabulary (e.g. <code>GOTO</code> , <code>PRINT</code>)
operand ... out of range 0..255	Numeric operand too large
program too large	More than 38 pairs
DELAY requires one operand	Missing or extra operands
LAMP requires ON or OFF	Invalid lamp sub-keyword
validation failed	Emitted image failed cart structure checks

Use `maxx check file` to validate syntax without writing a `.532` file.

8.11 What UltraMaxx BASIC is not

The following Commodore 64 BASIC features are **intentionally absent**:

C64 BASIC	UltraMaxx BASIC
Variables (A, X\$)	Not supported
IF / THEN	Not supported
GOTO / GOSUB	Not supported
FOR / NEXT	Not supported
Arithmetic expressions	Not supported
INPUT / READ / DATA	Not supported
String functions	Not supported
Inline interpreter	Not supported — compile only

Control flow is **strictly linear**: the executor runs steps in order from \$0200 until **END**.

8.12 Relationship to other chapters

Topic	See
Bytecode rules, modes, RAM limits	Chapter 1
Opcode hex reference	Chapter 2
Motion operand tuning	Chapter 3
Speech phonemes, music bytes	Chapter 4
Bootstrap stub, ROM map	Chapter 5
Cartridge authoring workflow	Cartridge/PROGRAMMING.md
PicoROM upload	Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/PICOROM.m

8.13 Quick command reference

Command	Purpose
<code>maxx compile file.bas</code>	Build .532 image
<code>maxx check file.bas</code>	Syntax check
<code>maxx validate file.532</code>	Verify cart structure
<code>maxx list file.532</code>	Human-readable step list
<code>maxx list --json</code>	Machine-readable trace (simulators)
<code>maxx upload file</code>	Compile (if needed) + PicoROM
<code>maxx simulate file.532</code>	Step preview

Previous: Chapter 6 — Input/output guide · **Next:** Appendices

9 Appendices

Reference tables for the Maxx Steele Programmer's Reference Guide.

9.1 A — Opcode abbreviations

See Quick reference for the full hex table. Names match tools/maxx_rom.py OPCODES dict.

9.2 B — Display segment table

Internal ROM table **\$F878** maps opcode indices to two-character LED segment patterns. Documented display names:

Index	Display	Opcode context
—	L, F, b, r	Drive
—	Uu, Ud, Au, Ad, Cr, Cc	Joints
—	HL, init, d	Lamp, home, delay
—	PLAY, SPEE, SS, CLr	Extended
—	End, beg	\$FF, \$FE

Full glyph bitmaps are embedded in maxx_internal_ROM.dsm (Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_i near label FULL / \$F878 references.

9.3 C — Memory map

Region	Address	Size	Purpose
Zero page	\$0000–\$00FF	256 B	Flags, pointers
Warm start	\$0100–\$0103	4 B	Copyright mirror
Stack	\$01FF ↓	—	6502 stack
Program RAM	\$0200–\$03FE	510 B	Bytecode
Music RAM	\$0400–\$04FF	256 B	Note pairs
Speech RAM	\$0500+	—	Phrases for \$83
I/O	\$1000	—	Timer
Display	\$1200	—	LED shift register
Speech	\$1400	—	Phoneme parallel port
Motors	\$1600, \$1C00	—	Motor drive
Cartridge	\$2000–\$B000	4K slots	Plug-in ROM
Internal ROM	\$E000–\$FFFF	8 KB	OS / interpreter

9.4 D — Zero-page registers

Addr	Name	Purpose
\$02	Status A	Speech error, backoff, power, drive flags
\$03	Status B	User control, execute gating
\$0D	Mode	0=immediate, 1=learn, 2=program, 3=execute
\$0F/\$10	Program pointer	Step in \$0200
\$11/\$13	Current op/operand	Entry state
\$24/\$25	Program byte pointer	Executor

9.5 E — Status bits

9.5.1 \$02 (from maxx_rom.py)

Bit	Label
0	SER (speech error)
1	Ebof (enable backoff)
2	PDon (power down on)
3	Edof (enable drive off)
4	SPon (speech on)

Keypad toggles (internal ROM): row 0 → SER, PAR; row 2 → Edon, Edof; row 3 → UCon, UCof; row 4 → Ebon, Ebof; row 5 → SPon, SPof.

9.5.2 \$03

Bit	Label
0	UCon (user control on)
1	SPon (speech enable)

Demo bootstrap: \$02 ← \$02, \$03 ← \$82.

9.6 F — Music duration table

Note durations for the music IRQ path are read from **\$F15B** (indexed 1-8 in maxx_internal_ROM.dsm (Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_internal_ROM.dsm)). Frequency/note bytes live in **\$0400**.

Complete note name → byte mapping is not yet transcribed in this archive.

9.7 G — Cartridge file layout

File offset = cartridge address – \$A000 for demo cart base.

File offset	Addr	Content
\$0000	\$A000	Entry vector
\$0002	\$A002	Copyright (17 bytes)
\$0013	\$A013	Bootstrap code
\$0035	\$A035	Program table
\$0081	\$A081	Phrase table
\$00BB	\$A0BB	Music table

9.8 H — maxx_rom.py commands

```
python3 tools/maxx_rom.py disasm PATH [--compare-dsm DSM]
python3 tools/maxx_rom.py validate PATH
python3 tools/maxx_rom.py template OUTPUT.532
python3 tools/maxx_rom.py opcodes OUTPUT.json
```

9.9 I — Internal ROM entry points

Partial list from maxx_internal_ROM.dsm (Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_internal_ROM.dsm):

Address	Role
\$E0B6	Post-bootstrap main loop
\$E0D1	Mode / executor loop
\$E6B5	Keycode table base
\$EF01	Music tune pointer helper
\$F1D8	Music IRQ region
\$F3D5	Speech output
\$F878	Display pattern table

9.10 J — Messages and errors

Message / flag	Cause
FULL	Program exceeds \$037F / RAM limit
Ser	Speech error status bit
validate copyright mismatch	Cart missing (c) 1985 CBS Toys
Missing FF FF	Program table not terminated

9.11 K — Bibliography

- R. Wind — maxx_internal_ROM.dsm(Chassis/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_internal_ROM.dsm), maxx_demo_ROM_532.dsm(Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/Firmware/Assembly/maxx_demo_ROM_532 (2002–2006)
- Factory manual — Chassis/Manual/MaxxSteeleReferenceGuide.pdf
- This repository — <https://github.com/webaugur/Maxx-Steele-1984-Robot>
- C64 Programmer’s Reference Guide — structural inspiration (Commodore, 1982)

9.12 L — Glossary

Term	Meaning
Bytecode	Opcode/operand pairs interpreted by internal ROM
Bootstrap	Short 6502 stub in cartridge that loads RAM tables
OOK	On-off keying RF modulation (27 MHz)
IF	Intermediate frequency (455 kHz in transmitter/receiver)
Phoneme	Speech sound unit; 4-bit codes to \$1400
Refdes	Schematic reference designator (U1, U400, ...)
.532	4 KB cartridge image file extension used in archive

10 Maxx Steele Quick Reference Card

Single-page summary. Full detail in chapters 1-7 and Appendices.

10.1 Modes (\$00)

Val	Mode
0	Immediate
1	Learn
2	Program
3	Execute

10.2 Key zero page

Addr	Use
\$02	Status A
\$03	Status B
\$0D	Mode
\$0F/\$10	Program step pointer
\$0200	Program RAM base
\$0400	Music RAM
\$0500	Speech RAM

10.3 Motion opcodes

Hex	Disp	Action
00	L	Left
01	F	Forward
02	b	Reverse
03	r	Right
04	Uu	Wrist up
05	Ud	Wrist down
06	Au	Arms up
07	Ad	Arms down
08	Cr	Claw rotate
09	Cc	Claw open/close
0A	HL	Lamp
0B	init	Home (00)
0C	d	Delay (sec)

10.4 Speech / music

Hex	Disp	Action
0E	S	Speech ROM
0F	SS	Speech shift
10	PS	Program speech
81	PLAY	Play tune

Hex	Disp	Action
82	SPEE	Speak ROM
83	SS	Speak RAM
84	CLr	Clear phrase
FE	beg	Marker
FF	End	End (FF FF)

10.5 Cartridge header (\$A000)

Off	Content
+0	Entry vector
+2	(c) 1985 CBS Toys
+\$13	Bootstrap
+\$35	Program
+81 <i>Phrases</i> +BB	Music

10.6 Common sequences

```

0C nn    delay nn seconds
0B 00    home
0A 01    lamp on
0A 00    lamp off
FF FF    end program

```

10.7 UltraMaxx BASIC (Ch 7)

Statement	Example
Delay	DELAY 2
Drive	FORWARD 20 BACK 20 LEFT 5 RIGHT 6
Joints	ARMS UP 40 WRIST DOWN 35 CLAW ROTATE 21 CLAW OPEN
Lamp	LAMP ON / LAMP OFF
Home	HOME
Music	PLAY 6
Speech	SPEAK 63 (ROM) · SAY 0 (RAM slot)
End	END

Cart limit: 38 steps max. **Not supported:** variables, IF, GOTO.

```

maxx compile FILE.bas -o FILE.532
maxx upload FILE.bas --device maxx_cart

```

10.8 Tools

```

maxx compile FILE.bas -o FILE.532
maxx-rom validate FILE.532
maxx-rom template FILE.532

```

11 Schematic Diagram Index

The Commodore 64 Programmer's Reference included a fold-out schematic. This index points to equivalent materials in the Maxx Steele archive.

11.1 Main logic board

Asset	Path	Status
Raster schematic (enhanced)	Mainboard/Schematic/MaxxSteele/Schematic_enh-v1.1.png	Available
SVG (v1.1)	Mainboard/Schematic/v1.1/MaxxSteele_Schematic.svg	Available
KiCad project	Mainboard/KiCAD/	Planned — digitization in progress

6502 CPU, RAM (M6116), cartridge interface, speech and motor glue.

11.2 Transmitter (remote)

Asset	Path	Status
KiCad schematic + PCB	Transmitter/KiCAD/Transmitter-27MHz.kicad_pro	Active
RE notes	Transmitter/ReverseEngineering	Available
BOM	Transmitter/transmitter-bom.md	Available

COP411L (U1), 455 kHz clock, 27 MHz OOK stage.

11.3 Receiver (robot RF)

Asset	Path	Status
KiCad schematic	Receiver/KiCAD/Receiver-Schematic only 27MHz.kicad_pro	
PCB layout	—	Not yet in archive

11.4 Cartridge

Asset	Path	Status
KiCad (CBSDemo)	Cartridge/Examples/CBSDemo/KiCAD/CBSDemo.kicad_pro	Active
KiCad (UltraMaxx)	Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/KiCAD/ (same PCB as CBSDemo)	Active
PicoROM (UltraMaxx U1)	Cartridge/Examples/UltraMaxx/PICOROM.md	Active

11.5 Face / speech / display

Asset	Path	Status
KiCad Datasheets	Face/KiCAD/ DataSheets/	Planned LC3100, LC8100, ET9420, COP41xL

11.6 Power module

Asset	Path	Status
KiCad	Power/KiCAD/	Planned

11.7 Paddle mirror accessory

Asset	Path	Status
Photo Schematic	PaddleMirror/Photos/ —	Available Needed

11.8 Chip cross-reference

Indexed datasheets with refdes where known: DataSheets/README.md.

ABOUT THE MAXX STEELE... ROBO FORCE TECHNICAL MANUAL...

Action figure compatibility... Advanced Robotic Speech and Sound... and high tech battle capabilities make the Maxx Steele Robot Force the most advanced robotic toy in its class for home, play, and educational use.

The MAXX STEELE ROBO FORCE TECHNICAL MANUAL tells you everything you need to know about your Maxx Steele robot. The perfect companion to your Robot Force Commander's Guide, this manual presents detailed information on everything from laser blasters to advanced machine language techniques. This book is a must for everyone from the beginner to the advanced robotic engineer.

For the beginner, the most complicated topics are explained with many sample programs and an easy-to-read wiring style. For the advanced robotic engineer, this book has been subjected to heavy pre-testing with your needs in mind. And it's designed so that you can easily get the most out of your Robot Force capabilities.
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ROBO FORCE

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